

UNICEF Cote D'Ivoire

Annual Report 2024

Acknowledgments

This narrative annual report summarizes the key programme results achieved by UNICEF in Cote D'Ivoire over the course of the year 2024. To learn more about the UNICEF programme in Cote D'Ivoire, including details at the outcome and output level, as well as financial analyses, please visit the UNICEF Transparency Portal www.open.unicef.org.

UNICEF would like to take this opportunity to express its gratitude to all partners whose collaboration and contributions supported the achievement of results for children.

UNICEF Cote D'Ivoire Annual Report 2024

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Contact:

United Nations Children's Fund

3 United Nations Plaza, New York, NY 10017, USA

Tel: +1 (212) 326-7000

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Section 1

Update on the Context

Côte d'Ivoire, home to a dynamic population of 29.6 million[1], ranks as the third most populous nation in West Africa. The country is making significant socio-economic progress toward achieving the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) targets, propelled by its youthful demographic, with 75.3% of its population under 35.

Hosting the African Cup of Nations (CAN) and claiming its third title since the tournament's inception have strengthened its regional leadership and reinforced its ambition to establish itself as a leading force on the continent. Youth participation in CAN activities in 2024 was unprecedented, which gave rise to a national volunteer movement supported by the Minister of Youth. It also boosted the government response to the challenges faced by youth, both in civic participation and in youth development and skill certification, in a socio-economic landscape that remained complex, with regional inequalities and gaps in education and vocational training. The government's youth programme, supported by UNICEF, made significant progress, aligning with the 2022-2025 Strategic Plan and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. The programme reached over 648,435[2] young people, with 259,096 receiving vocational training, 3.8 million sensitized to critical issues and 18 infrastructures rehabilitated. Youth participation saw a significant boost, with 40,872 adolescents and youth engaging in civic actions, a 254% increase from 2023. With UNICEF's support, the Ministry of Youth established a civic service programme to foster youth engagement in civic matters while providing practical skills.

In addition to focusing on human capital, public investment in infrastructure, particularly in the digital and transport sectors, a robust industrial base and the exploration of new oil reserves contributed to the continued leadership of Côte d'Ivoire as the largest, fastest and most diversified growing economy in West African Economic and Monetary Union. Economic growth is 3 percentage points above the sub-Saharan Africa average[3], the country being a key supply hub for the Sahel and Francophone West Africa.

Despite 2024 being a pre-electoral year, Côte d'Ivoire continued to enjoy economic resilience, stability and security. However, the ongoing conflict in the Sahel and the deteriorating security situation in Burkina Faso led to a rise in asylum-seekers from Burkina Faso, with 25,921 people[4] (15,034 children) crossing into Côte d'Ivoire from January to December 2024. By December 2024, Côte d'Ivoire hosted some 70,500 asylum seekers from Burkina Faso. Most displaced populations in northern Côte d'Ivoire are women and children (82%), with 41% being school-age children and over 19% children under five. This situation puts additional pressure on the limited resources of host communities and on the availability of basic social services.

This large-scale population movement coincided with the onset of the mpox epidemic that began on 24 July 2024. By 16 December 2024 there were 484 suspected cases, including 107 confirmed cases across 35 health

districts, with 106 recoveries and one death. Children under 15 accounted for 41.1% of confirmed cases. In response, UNICEF helped to develop the national mpox epidemic response plan, supported risk communication and community engagement (RCCE) activities, and deployed four temporary screening and treatment centres with infection prevention and control supplies in the two most affected health districts. These efforts helped to control the epidemic. Additionally, in 2024, 889 dengue cases were reported, with UNICEF focusing on epidemiological surveillance and RCCE.

Despite economic growth, poverty remains high at 37.5%, following a previous decline from 44.4% in 2015 to 39.4% in 2021. Vulnerable groups, including children, young people and women, are most affected, with 46% of children living in monetarily poor households and over 8.2 million children (62.5%)[5] experiencing multidimensional poverty (deprivations in at least 3 out of 7 poverty dimensions). Poverty is particularly pronounced in rural areas, where the monetary poverty rate is 54.5%, significantly higher than the national average. Inequalities persist, especially between rural and urban areas, notably compared to the city of Abidjan.

The 2024 Situation Analysis and socio-behavioural studies conducted in 2024 highlight the need for socio-behavioural change and innovative social marketing in Côte d'Ivoire to boost demand for social services, support children's rights, and mobilize community participation.

SDG3/KRC1[6]. The Côte d'Ivoire Immunization Programme, historically funded by GAVI (40% in 2024) and other partners, saw vaccination coverage for Penta 3 (0-11 months) rise from 72% in 2020 to 79% in 2023[7]. However, nearly 67,000 zero-dose children remain, especially in northern regions and cities. In 2024 UNICEF supported both the Abidjan Declaration on transitioning to domestic financing and the national initiative to reduce the number of zero-dose children in 38 districts in need. The 2024 Universal Healthcare Coverage reform, which enrolled over 50% of the population, is a crucial entry point for enhancing health protection for vulnerable children and women.

SDG2/KRC2. Côte d'Ivoire's commitment to tackling malnutrition has made nutrition a major priority and resulted in strengthened regulatory frameworks, expanded facility-based interventions and multisectoral community-based approaches, supported by domestic investment. The country is on track to achieve global nutrition targets, with exclusive breastfeeding rates rising to 34%. To maintain these gains, ongoing efforts should address child food poverty (76%) and anemia (61%), and focus on evidence-based decision-making, reducing inequalities, and tackling emerging challenges like climate change and unhealthy food marketing.

SDG4/KRC3&4. Government-led efforts, supported by UNICEF and its partners, resulted in notable progress in preschool attendance, which increased in one year by 0.4 percentage points to 11.6% in 2024 (10.8% for boys and 12.4% for girls)[8]. This modest increase reflects the impact of UNICEF's advocacy for expanding preschool programmes to enhance fundamental learning outcomes. Primary completion rate also improved, rising from

78.6% (girls at 80.0% and boys at 76.2%) in 2021 to 79.1% in 2024 (girls at 84.1% and boys at 74.4%), with gender parity favouring girls. The improvements stem from efforts since 2021 to reduce dropouts through community sensitization and resource allocation. In lower-secondary education, the completion rate improved from 60.7% (girls at 57.5% and boys at 63.5%) to 72% (girls at 75.5% and boys at 68.7 %) over the same period.

SDG8&16/KRCs5&7. Violence against children (VAC) and child labour in Côte d'Ivoire are declining (VAC: 87% in 2016 to 75% in 2021; child labour: 31% in 2016 to 22% in 2021), but the country is not on track to meet SDG targets. Violence threatens economic gains and progress, necessitating a whole-of-society approach for effective solutions. Social service coverage has improved, with social centres increasing from 81 in 2020 to 191 in 2024 and child justice services from 11 to 17. However, service coordination and quality need improvement. Birth registration for children under one increased by two percentage points[9] from 2023 but remains low. Decentralization is key for UNICEF support to achieve universal birth registration by 2030.

SDG6/KRC8. Despite previous gains with open defecation decreasing from 33.8% at national level (56.5% in rural area) in 2012 to 19.2% at national level (36.7% in rural areas) in 2021, in 2024 the open defecation rate remained high, particularly in rural areas (38%) and at the national level (21%)[10]. Children and their families in Côte d'Ivoire continued to face significant challenges, with 63.8% lacking access to basic sanitation services and 69% lacking access to basic drinking water, especially in rural regions. These critical deprivations, coupled with poor hygiene practices, are major contributors to diarrheal diseases, the third leading cause of mortality among children under five. Despite substantial investments in urban water supply, the rural exodus and rapid urbanization have hindered progress, keeping access to basic water services stagnant at around 90% in urban areas.

Recognizing the impact of climate change, marked by rising temperatures, droughts and floods, which further increase the risks and vulnerabilities for the population, especially children and women, the government negotiated a US\$1.3 billion Resilience and Sustainability arrangement with the International Monetary Fund. Following publication of the latest World Bank economic report and the country climate and development report findings, the government aims to ensure that the next National Development Plan (NDP) 2026-2030 will be a 'green' NDP.

All data are from the Situation Analysis 2024, unless otherwise stated.

[1]National Statistics Agency, Census 2021.

[2]Communique of the Council of Ministers of 18/09/2024.

[3]IMF, Côte d'Ivoire: Favoriser la transformation économique et l'adaptation au changement climatique,14/01/2025

[4]UNHCR Côte d'Ivoire, SitRep on asylum seekers, 31/12/2024.

[5]UNICEF, N-MODA, 2024.

[6]KRC stands for Key Result for Children.

[7]WHO/UNICEF Estimates of National Immunization Coverage.

[8]Ministry of National Education, EMIS, 2023-2024.

[9]Ministry of Interior and Security, Statistics Yearbook, 2023.

[10]WHO/UNICEF Joint Monitoring Programme (JMP) 2023.

Section 2

Major Achievements and UNICEF's Contribution

In 2024 UNICEF, following the Secretary General's guidance on enhancing a child rights-based approach within the United Nations, intensified its leadership on advocacy for children's rights centring it around major national rallying events, including the CAN, by partnering with national football champions, such as Sebastien Haller. This was a major push for child rights, prioritizing the right to a legal identity and birth registration as the cornerstone for all child rights. Additionally, UNICEF leveraged Côte d'Ivoire's leadership role and participation in global forums, including the country's delegation at the UN General Assembly and the first global End Violence Against Children Conference.

The year was marked by a robust print, digital and TV/radio media presence, with 2,082 mentions, reaching a potential audience of 112,039,478 people, based on the media monitoring report. This represents an increase of almost 50% on 2023 (1,418 mentions), which was already a record year and a significant push for the child rights agenda in the country through the media channel. This outreach was further amplified by the Young Bloggers and Young Reporters, who strengthened youth engagement through traditional and social media channels (677 blogs/vlogs/comics and 440 radio programmes broadcast on 12 local radio stations on children's rights issues). The social media posts reached 7,000,559 people and 528,204 engagements.

In 2024 UNICEF Côte d'Ivoire received the prestigious "Brand Africa" Award, making it the most admired brand in the non-profit sector for its exceptional impact on people, society and the environment.

Programmatically 2024 was an intensive year. Significant efforts were dedicated to the complex processes and consultations for the new National Development Plan (NDP) 2026-2030, the United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework (UNSDCF) 2026-2030, and the formulation of the new Country Programme Document (CPD) 2026-2030. These processes were led by the Ministry of Economy, Development, and Planning, with UNICEF playing a crucial role as a technical and financial partner. UNICEF actively participated in the NDP review, which identified priority challenges and development strategies for the upcoming NDP 2026-2030, and provided technical support for major NDP development milestones. Enhanced advocacy efforts led to prioritizing human development and investments into social sectors under the next NDP 2026-2030. Concurrently, UNICEF continued implementing the priorities of the current country programme, which are aligned with the NDP 2021-2025, the UNSDCF 2021-2025, UNICEF's Global Strategic Plan, the Gender Action Plan 2022-2025, UNICEF contribution to Africa's development agendas, and the Key Results for Children (KRC) in the Western and Central Africa region. The implementation leveraged UNICEF's technical leadership and partnerships, collaborating with UN agencies, stakeholders, civil society, national and local authorities, and the private sector in key strategic areas. Some significant results for children achieved in 2024 are presented below:

Goal Area 1. Every child survives and thrives, with access to nutritious diets, quality health care, nurturing practices and essential supplies. KRC#1: Immunization; KRC#2 Prevention of Stunting

Côte d'Ivoire's health system marked a turning point in 2024 when the country adopted the Immunization Financing Transition Plan, enabling it to discontinue GAVI subsidized financing of vaccines by 2030. This was possible due to the strong will of the government and the timely technical expertise on domestic financing and vaccine supply management provided by UNICEF Côte d'Ivoire, WCARO and health partners.

As co-lead of the UN Basic Social Services Results Group, together with the World Health Organization (WHO), UNICEF's support to the government significantly advanced maternal and neonatal health, HIV, immunization and community health as part of universal health coverage reform. UNICEF supported the introduction of the malaria vaccine, Côte d'Ivoire being the 10th country worldwide to do so, with 89,985 children aged 6-23 months vaccinated in 38 out of 113 health districts, thereby significantly improving the chances of survival of children under five since malaria still remains the primary cause of death.

Overall, in terms of immunization coverage -KRC#1, by end 2024, based on administrative data, 1,122,988 children received DPT3 (95% vs 96% in 2023), 1,060,229 were vaccinated with BCG (88% vs 87% in 2023) and 1,105,142 received the first dose of measles/rubella vaccine (93%, as in 2023). In mass campaigns, 9,384,252 children under five were vaccinated against polio (107%), and 6.7 million children under five received the measles/rubella vaccine (98%).

Through cross-sectoral efforts integrating SBC and Youth and Adolescent-related strategies, UNICEF improved vaccination coverage, reaching additional under-vaccinated and zero-dose children, the latter strategy having been reinforced in 2024 with support from WCARO and HQ. The collection and use of socio-behavioural data also aided the development of the SBC plan to address dengue epidemics and improve interventions for promoting HPV and malaria vaccine demand. These interventions were conducted based on U-Report polls on the acceptability of vaccines.

UNICEF enhanced the health system's resilience by launching the digitalization of community health processes in five districts of the Poro region. The initiative equipped 450 Community Health Workers (CHWs) and 150 supervisors with tablets and smartphones for improved care and real-time data collection – all linked up to the District Health Information System platform. This innovative initiative will be scaled up in 2025, covering immunization and malaria programmes. Meanwhile, among 541 babies born to HIV-positive mothers, 91% were tested before 2 months, an improvement compared to 78% in 2023. These improvements are driven by CHW involvement.

In support of maternal and child health, UNICEF expanded Kangaroo Mother Care (KMC) units from 15 to 19 covering a target of 25,000 premature low birth weight babies and distributed 1,188,985 mother and child health books and 50,000 midwifery practice guides to health facilities. This helped 102,370 deliveries to be attended by skilled health professionals (compared to 98,866 in 2023), and 953 premature and low-birthweight babies survived through KMC (vs 791 in 2023). UNICEF also built the capacity of 1,350 health professionals and supported health facilities and CHWs to improve quality of care for pneumonia, diarrhea and malaria – leading causes of under-five deaths. At the community level, 1,183,127 children under five were visited by CHWs (compared to 943,032 children visited in 2023), with 11,252 children treated for diarrhea with ORS-Zinc (vs 10,619 in 2023), 25,541 children receiving antibiotics for pneumonia (vs 22,656 in 2023) and 20,624 treated for malaria (vs 29,119 in 2023).

In 2024 an additional 1,204,845 adolescents and youth (50% female and 300 living with disabilities) were reached with information on HIV prevention, early pregnancy prevention, HPV vaccination, mental health and nutrition, bringing the total to 3,141,546. The U-Report platform was used to raise the opinion of young people on HPV and malaria vaccines, and the surveys responses influenced the updating of the information centres and the communication strategies by the Ministry of Health and UNICEF. The information centres were also updated on polio and mpox to better inform adolescents and youth. The U-Test model continued to be deployed in 110 health districts, scaling up the national response to HIV prevention among adolescents and youth, particularly among key populations.

In 2024, as the lead of the Nutrition Partners Group, partnering with the European Union co-lead, UNICEF significantly contributed to enhancing the nutrition policy environment. This effort resulted in the approval of the costed National Multisectoral Nutrition Strategy (NMNS) 2024-2030 and the implementation of evidence-based programming through the National Nutrition Information Platform. Discussions on fiscal policies to promote healthy diets were initiated with a potential for a systemic impact in 2025. UNICEF established itself as a key partner in the national high-level dialogue for the upcoming Nutrition for Growth Summit 2025 and the implementation of the NMNS. The strategy emphasizes system strengthening, innovation and innovative financing for nutrition. UNICEF also maintained an active role in strategic discussions on the 'multisectoral community-based approach' and food systems for nutrition, collaborating with the local authorities and the private sector, including women farmers' associations, small and medium enterprises (SMEs) and the national Youth Network for Nutrition.

With UNICEF's support, 21,029 children aged 6-59 months recovered from severe acute malnutrition, marking a 22-percentage point increase from 2023. Vitamin A supplementation was successfully delivered through routine healthcare services in 73 of 113 health districts and through door-to-door campaigns, supported by the U-report network. Additionally, 33 new maternities were officially designated as 'baby-friendly,' bringing the total to 153. All these high-impact nutrition interventions contributed significantly to improving the survival and growth of children.

UNICEF introduced innovations, such as multiple supplements for young children, lipid-based supplements in highly vulnerable areas and targeted community-based multisectoral actions for asylum-seekers. UNICEF also supported the maintenance and development of 73 community-based platforms for nutrition and collaborated with women's groups as part of the 'First Foods' initiative, which is taking off with partner and donor support.

Goal Area 2: Every Child, including Adolescents, learns and acquire skills for the future; KRC#3: Equitable and sustainable access to Education; KRC#4: Improved Learning outcomes

In 2024 UNICEF enhanced Côte d'Ivoire's leadership of the Conférence des Ministres de l'Éducation des États et Gouvernements de la Francophonie (Conference of Ministers of Education from French-speaking States and Governments), or CONFEMEN (2024-2025), by boosting the country's international visibility at the UN General Assembly side events in September. This year Côte d'Ivoire was recognized as a pioneer in education reform, having adopted an inclusive education strategy to facilitate access to and/or return to school for children obliged to abandon their education for various reasons (health, pregnancy, travel and others) and a primary education learning strategy to improve learning outcomes. Additionally, the country launched the regionalization of teacher recruitment to address the significant shortage in the teaching workforce. Côte d'Ivoire's leadership in digitalization and gender equity further positioned UNICEF as a key partner thanks to its technical assistance in these areas.

Focusing on systemic reform to improve KRC#3 indicators, UNICEF, lead of the UN Education Results Group, reinforced its institutional advocacy, which led to an interministerial decree among the three education ministries, addressing the issue of over 2.3 million out-of-school children. This enables integrated strategies across the ministries. Moreover, cross-sectoral initiatives (adolescent health, washing, child protection, SBC) have led to the creation and near-finalization of a World Bank partnership for US\$5 million and another with the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) for US\$3 million. These partnerships aim to facilitate girls' access to secondary school and reduce the risk of drop-out.

In 2024 14,181 children returned to school due to UNICEF-supported investment into new constructions and alternative education pathways, including temporary learning spaces for 2,379 child asylum-seekers. This number supplements the 73,827 students reintegrated between 2021 and 2023. In total more than 88,000 children were reintegrated for a target of 74,424.

Through UNICEF's support, a major breakthrough was achieved with the introduction of the 'Certificat de Qualification aux Métiers', which enables youth trained by Master Artisans to gain formal recognition for their skills. This new certification system not only paves the way for improved professional integration of out-of-school young people but also promises to further reduce the NEET rate.

To achieve system-wide change, UNICEF supported the creation of regional risk-prevention and management units and, with the Ministry of National Education, developed a “safe school” protocol outlining major risks and appropriate responses to risks, including climate change impact.

UNICEF's ongoing drive to generate evidence for decision-making included Data Must Speak research with Innocenti, identifying good practices in high-performing schools with equal resources. These best practices will be disseminated and proposed for scaling up to improve primary learning outcomes and to contribute to KRC#4 in 2025 to enable achieving results while optimizing implementation costs and increasing local ownership and accountability.

UNICEF continued to innovate to align educational activities with demand. Several initiatives are being piloted, such as the “Mobile Digital Classroom,” providing access to the national distance education platform in non-connected areas, the “itinerant classroom,” offering basic education to out-of-school children in cocoa-growing regions, and the “Mobile Training Unit” providing short certified technical training for youth in remote areas. These pilots will be analysed for potential scaling up with the government and partners in 2025.

Goal Area 3. Every child is protected from violence, exploitation, abuse, neglect and harmful practices; KRC#7: Birth registration

In 2024 UNICEF's advocacy led to the revamping of the Interministerial Child Protection Committee's work. As a result, the Committee of Experts examined and validated the costed national child protection strategy.

UNICEF's efforts also resulted in Côte d'Ivoire renewing its commitment to ending violence against children. This was achieved through participation in the first ministerial-level Violence Against Children international conference and the development of the Spotlight 2.0 initiative, a joint UN effort led by the Minister of Family, Women and Children. These initiatives prioritized children's rights on the political agenda and promoted a harmonized approach to violence and GBV (#KRC5). Some 5,810 children received care and assistance through UNICEF-supported services in 2024, an increase of 10% compared to 2023. Since 2021, 21,198 victims of violence have been reached exceeding the target by six percentage points.

Government efforts to eliminate child labour continued, with Côte d'Ivoire being the only country to experience a ten-percentage point decrease in child labour over the last decade. This political will translate into the decentralization of child labour coordination plans. UNICEF played a key role in involving private sector companies in child protection system strengthening, including birth registration, by leveraging resources to address the root causes of child labour. UNICEF provided guidance for an action framework signed by the US,

Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana and the World Cocoa Foundation, adopting a child protection system-strengthening approach, a major breakthrough within the landscape perspective.

In 2024, with UNICEF support, the Ministry of Family, Women and Children became fully autonomous in managing the child protection information system, including producing the annual statistical yearbook, a critical tool for decision-making. Support for the digital case management system continued and gained political backing. An MoU will be signed for scaling up the digital system following an end-of-year evaluation.

Digital transformation support extended to the justice system in 2024 and will be scaled up in 2025. UNICEF's work on strengthening the social service workforce progressed with the development of e-learning modules. National guidelines on parenting were developed in 2024 to be operationalized in 2025 through social workers, with a focus on strengthening the family care of children with a disability, a major breakthrough in a country where 9% of children live with a disability.

In addition to inter-operability, decentralization was added to improve birth registration of children under one (#KRC7), achieving a two-percentage point increase from 2023 to 57.9%. A total of 621,476 children under one were registered in 2024, bringing the total to 2,410,000 children under 1 registered with UNICEF support since 2021, equivalent to 94% of the cumulative target of 2,573,292 children. Business process analyses were conducted in regions with the highest number of unregistered children. The government confirmed the establishment of civil registration centres in all university and regional hospitals in 2025, a major result of UNICEF's advocacy. The role of over 3,000 social workers in the birth registration process was formalized to ensure equity and to leave no child behind.

Goal area 4: Every child, including adolescents, has access to safe and equitable water, sanitation and hygiene services, and lives in a safe and sustainable climate and environment; KRC#8: End open defecation

Year 2024 was a transformative year for WASH, with UNICEF continuing to support the government and leading the dialogue of the WASH Donor Group to create an enabling environment for sustainable access to WASH services, both in development and emergency situations. Special attention focused on addressing the structural challenges around the mobilization of green climate funds for the WASH sector. With UNICEF's support, a climate rationale for water, sanitation and the hygiene sector was developed. In 2024 UNICEF also launched its Environment and Social Impact Assessment to ensure that all infrastructural investment is subjected to proper safeguards.

Upscaling of WASH infrastructure resulted in an additional 12,500 people (6,500 men, 6,000 women) in rural areas in the priority regions gaining access to basic water services, bringing the total to 58,838 since 2021. Of these, 2,000 were able to access a climate-resilient WASH services, using its innovative, multipurpose, solar-powered water systems. UNICEF continued leveraging government investments, which quadrupled since 2023 to reach 1,000 small solar water systems providing access to water to at least 2 million people.

UNICEF remained the lead contributor to SDG 6.2 - KRC#8. An additional 19,953 people (10,376 men and 9,577 women), who stopped open defecation in 46 rural communities from three additional sub-prefectures, also have access to basic sanitation since the Open Defecation Free certification criteria include improved toilet at the household level. From 2021 to 2024 a total of 132,043 people gained access to at least basic sanitation with UNICEF direct support, exceeding the CPD target of 106,223. The shift from the Community-Led Total Sanitation sub-prefecture to a regional approach was launched in 2024 in Worodougou region under the Minister of Water and Sanitation leadership and paves the way for larger scale, faster results in coming years.

To operationalize the national WASH-in-healthcare-facilities (HCFs) strategy 2023-2030, developed with UNICEF support through the coupling of WASH with health strategies and the pooling of resources, a package of climate-resilient WASH services was provided to 27 HCFs, including two hospitals, covering at least 165,000 patients.

The shift from the 3-star WASH school to the inspectorate approach was upscaled in 2024 in strong partnership with the Ministry of National Education, resulting in 223 schools benefiting from the training, totalling 49,288 schoolchildren, including 8,091 schoolchildren who gained access to WASH package services in 45 schools. They acquired essential life skills and best practices in water, sanitation and hygiene, with a focus on menstrual hygiene management in schools and communities.

Goal Area 5. Every child and adolescent have access to inclusive social protection and lives free from poverty

UNICEF's support to the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) reporting mechanisms led to significant achievements, with civil society producing a report on child rights progress and implementation of the CRC recommendations, reinforcing advocacy for children's rights. UNICEF also included enhanced reflection of child rights in the national Universal Periodic Review report. A review of the legal framework on child rights and business, following discussions on CRC General Comment No. 16, is anticipated to enhance the protection of children's rights within business operations. This is crucial for Côte d'Ivoire, the largest and fastest-growing economy in the subregion. UNICEF has redeveloped a partnership with an organization of people with disabilities and consulted with government bodies and civil societies organizations to better understand their needs.

Upholding UNICEF's leadership for data on children in support of advocacy for children's agenda, the generation of evidence through the Situation Analysis of Children (SitAn), the analysis of equity and vulnerability and the in-depth analyses of determinants of child outcomes have all contributed to providing the government and its partners with solid new evidence on the situation of children in Côte d'Ivoire, particularly the most vulnerable, and feeding into the Common Country Analysis.

In 2024 UNICEF enhanced its support for socio-behavioural data generation through research on the causes of child labour in Nawa and on the determinants of balanced nutritional diet for children under the First Food initiative, in support of the scaling-up of innovations. Additionally, the expansion of the community engagement in Bounkani, Nawa and Tchologo included 148 localities to gather feedback, collect data and co-create solutions for child rights, with local radio participation. This is expected to strengthen local ownership and the sustainability of results.

In 2024 UNICEF expanded its focus on local governance and participatory budgeting, thereby increasing its target localities from six to nine. This shift allowed 180 adolescents and youth in six localities to benefit from capacity-building initiatives. Engagement with local stakeholders in the remaining three localities prepared for future scale-up of child-friendly, participatory governance initiatives. To enhance youth empowerment in local leadership, UNICEF incorporated modules on child rights and public finance management into the participatory budgeting training programmes. Furthermore, developing a public finance for child strategy will guide its agenda on leveraging domestic resources.

Looking ahead, UNICEF plans further collaboration with the government and partners through the local governance subgroup to establish a national approach to participatory local governance, including participatory budgeting. This initiative aims to institutionalize participatory budgeting, bridging the gap between local practices and the national legal framework governing local entity management.

Humanitarian action and resilience, gender equity and cross-cutting results

Responding to the Central Sahel Crisis and its adverse effects in northern Côte d'Ivoire, UNICEF led UN agency efforts to enhance the resilience of communities and systems, while providing humanitarian response under the L1 emergency procedure for coastal countries in 2024. UNICEF addressed the humanitarian needs of 180,910 people, including 168,117 children. UNICEF also responded to the mpox epidemic and climate change effects—violent winds and flooding impacting social infrastructure—in north and south-west Côte d'Ivoire.

Strengthened capacity and coordination for emergency preparedness and response, including on integrating gender into Core Commitments for Children, with support from the WCARO, contributed to reinforcing the emergency capacity of UNICEF staff and of Nutrition, Education, WASH and Child Protection sectoral working groups (Cluster leads). Coordination with local government and civil society actors, along with locally prepositioned supplies, were key drivers of the results achieved. This was notwithstanding that only 37% of US\$13.65 million requested under Humanitarian Action for Children was funded, in a context of limited

humanitarian resources and government's non-declaration of a state of emergency.

Underfunding affected all sectors except Nutrition, where targets were exceeded: 4,111 severely malnourished children under five were treated (target: 3,000) and 146,594 children were supplemented with Vitamin A (target: 80,000). UNICEF provided safe water for drinking and domestic needs to 11,777 people, including 4,938 children (target 25,000 people); 3,057 people received hygiene kits (target 30,000 people); 39,510 children (refugees and host communities) vaccinated against measles (target:70,000); 22,016 children (10,523 girls) received individual learning materials (target: 25,000), and 688 children received individual case management for their protection (target:1,000). Furthermore, 78,283 people were reached with vital information and resources on child protection, including children's rights, gender-based violence (GBV), protection from violence, and reporting channels for sexual exploitation and abuse (compared to only 8,059 in 2023).

In 2024 office-wide accountability and capacity for gender equity was reinforced, with 75% of staff having completed the Gender Pro training. Guided by the UNICEF Gender Policy 2021–2030 and Gender Action Plan 2022–2025, gender analysis was integrated throughout the new CPD 2026–2030 development process. The initial findings of the Gender Programmatic Review, conducted with WCARO support and steered by the Gender Taskforce, enabled the adoption of the programming approach focused on addressing and transforming harmful gender norms and power imbalances as a core change strategy within the Theory of Change and results framework.

The office championed adolescent girls' leadership and participation by effectively adopting the Adolescent Girls Programme Strategy 2022–2025 and the Girl-Intentional Approach in West and Central Africa 2024 across sectors and implementing targeted, girls-focused programming. UNICEF also played a complementary yet pivotal role in GBV risk mitigation in emergencies, collaborating with the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) and UN Women on joint programming for resilience in the northeast.

Enablers and office management results

The office strengthened its internal management and control mechanisms through improved financial management, supply and asset management, recruitment and talent development, while enhancing work-life balance and the psychological safety of staff and creating a people-focused and organizational culture-driven environment. All this helped to improve the quality of programme implementation. Over 90% of targets outlined in the Annual Management Plan were successfully achieved.

Section 3

Partnerships

In 2024 UNICEF Côte d'Ivoire continued to focus on enhancing, diversifying and leveraging partnerships with public and private actors, the UN system and civil society to accelerate KRCs and drive systemic change for children in Côte d'Ivoire.

Public Partnerships for Resource Mobilization and Influence. UNICEF's partnerships with the Government of Côte d'Ivoire and various international organizations, including GAVI, the Global Fund, Global Partnership for Education (GPE), the World Bank, the Peacebuilding Fund (PBF), and bilateral partnerships with Canada, the European Commission, the French Development Agency, Japan, Kreditanstalt für Wiederaufbau (KfW), the Netherlands, South Korea, Switzerland and the United States Agency for International Development, resulted in contracts totalling approximately US\$70.9 million. This funding contributed significantly to improved outcomes for children and addressed gaps in progress toward the SDGs. In 2024 key areas of focus included:

- **Health (KRC#1):** Enhancing immunization and community healthcare.
- **Malnutrition:** Preventing and treating malnutrition.
- **Education (KRC# 3&4):** Increasing access to climate-resilient school facilities and facilitating the school-to-work transition for vulnerable adolescents and youth.
- **Birth Registration (KRC#7):** Enhancing birth registration processes.
- **Child Labour (KRC#5):** Reducing child labour in cocoa-producing regions.
- **Youth Empowerment:** Empowering youth as agents of change in their communities.

UNICEF Regular Resources supported results under the flagship initiative on community health and nutrition (FRANC), HPV and girls' empowerment (Girl Power). Regular resources were critical for the emergency response, especially for the mpox epidemic.

Since the start of the country programme in 2021, UNICEF's resource mobilization efforts have secured donor commitments covering over 109% of the entire Country Programme (2021-2025), which prompted a revision of the ceiling. This success highlights the potential to tackle new vulnerabilities in the 2026-2030 programme.

UNICEF's leadership in several technical and financial partner groups, such as Nutrition-Early Childhood Development, Social Protection and WASH, has helped to leverage resources for children and facilitated a coordinated approach for supporting national reforms and new policies.

Strengthening UN Collaboration. UNICEF continued playing a significant role in enhancing UN coordination for the Central Sahel crisis response. UNICEF led the review of the UN resilience programme extension, involving 10 UN agencies, with a budget of US\$90 million for phase 1, with negotiations ongoing for an extension initially estimated at US\$256 million. UNICEF also promoted joint resource mobilization efforts, securing US\$2.5 million from Canada for a joint UN Women/UNFPA/UNICEF programme on girls' health and rights, signed in 2024, with negotiations ongoing for an extension.

In 2024 collaboration with specific UN agencies was further strengthened, including with the following international organizations:

- **WHO:** On nutrition information management and mental health (UN joint programme).
- **UNDP and United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC),** with United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) as a technical partner: A new inter-agency partnership programme was established for the digital transformation of the justice system, including justice for children (SDG fund-supported joint programme).
- **UN Women and UNFPA:** On girls' health and rights, under the UN Resilience Programme in northern Côte d'Ivoire.
- **Global Partnership for Education (GPE)/UNESCO, World Bank:** UNICEF's strong position in the sectoral dialogue led to the creation and near-finalization of two partnerships, with UNESCO and with the World Bank, for implementing two GPE-supported pilots to reinforce girls' access to secondary school.
- **World Bank:** UNICEF partnered with the World Bank in support of social sector reform, including the Social Service Workforce, which was recognized as pioneering in the global World Bank-UNICEF strategic dialogue, paving the way for increased political commitment and quality of care.
- **ILO and IOM:** Fight against the root causes of child labour in the cocoa-producing regions (EU/Swiss-funded UN joint programme) in the Nawa region.
- **UNDP and IOM:** Cross-border and borderland peacebuilding (PBF joint programmes).

- **United Nations Girls' Education Initiative (UNGEI) and UNESCO International Institute for Education Planning (IIEP):** Partnership created within the Gender-Centred Initiative framework, with UNICEF-UNGEI and UNESCO IIEP collaboration.
- Existing partnerships are leveraged to strengthen the child protection system – including **online protection** – through the One UN approach.
- For several years, the CO has collaborated with UNICEF Innocenti to produce education **data useful for programming, sectoral dialogue and decision-making**. With this partnership, UNICEF Côte d'Ivoire is finalizing a \$900,000 GPE grant application to strengthen evidence on the deployment of digital innovation.

Business for Results - Private Sector Engagement and Public/Private Partnerships (PPPs). Solid private sector engagement efforts in support of programme implementation, working both 'with' and 'on' businesses, continued in 2024. Since the CPD's onset, US\$33 million has been raised from private donors through 14 UNICEF National Committees (NatComs) (Belgium, France, Germany, Iceland, Italy, Japan, Luxembourg, Netherlands, South Korea, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, UK, UK), local branches of international businesses and individuals.

To better direct **private investments towards national child protection system strengthening**, UNICEF:

1. Convened private sector support for child protection systems, including birth registration, by leveraging resources to combat child labour.
2. Strengthened on-the-ground coordination through joint efforts to combat child labour in cocoa-producing regions.
3. Contributed to developing an action framework signed in 2024 between the United States, Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana, and the World Cocoa Foundation, that led to a strengthened child protection system.

UNICEF collaborated with local businesses to offer internships to 255 girls through the 'Girl Power' initiative, which the government is now scaling up. This initiative plays a vital role in enhancing youth employment skills and fostering innovation in the green and blue economy. Similar collaboration supported the Youth Agency Marketplace initiative to upskill young people with 21st century skills. UNICEF reached more than 5,000 beneficiaries through the "Blue and Green" employment event organized in the first quarter of 2024 and through the Camp Green Coast.

UNICEF has been a leader in the First Foods Initiative, which aims to enhance access to safe and nutritious foods for young children through collaboration with local SMEs. Japan's National Committee for UNICEF has supported this innovative approach since its inception in Côte d'Ivoire and has expanded its support for Phase II.

As part of its commitment to finding solutions to the learning difficulties observed in the classroom, UNICEF is committed to digital transformation, to developing tools to reinforce learning and to ensuring educational continuity and access for children in disadvantaged areas. A partnership has been established with a private service provider to build "Ma classe digitale mobile" (my mobile digital classroom), enabling children in non-connected areas to access the "Mon école à la maison" national distance-learning platform, in response to the digital divide observed in school learning continuity.

Partnerships for Communications and Advocacy. Important new partnerships included close collaborations with the newspaper Fraternité Matin and the Côte d'Ivoire Press Agency (AIP). Both institutions received equipment donations to better promote children's rights through podcasts and other media products. In national broadcaster RTI studios, a banner displaying UNICEF's ethical media charter was unveiled, officially affirming the public broadcaster's commitment to giving children a voice and protecting their rights.

Section 4

Challenges, Lessons Learned and Future Outlook

The Situation Analysis of Children and Adolescents, its compendium of studies and research (N-MODA, Equity Analysis, In-depth analyses on out-of-school children and maternal, neonatal and infant mortality and the Evaluation of the Country Programme (2021–2025) highlighted progress in realizing child rights through tackling the determinants of child rights deprivations, as per the programme theory of change. It also outlines some key challenges and lessons learned. In 2025 the programme will build on lessons learned to address the main challenges and set priorities for the current cycle's last year and for the next cycle.

Challenges

In 2024 **programmatic challenges** included the lack of up-to-date data from administrative systems to inform and monitor strategies and high-impact interventions. To counter this, qualitative research helped identify ways to address issues like low learning quality, high numbers of out-of-school children and maternal, neonatal and infant mortality.

Despite considerable effort and investment by UNICEF – involving HQ/Innovation, WCARO and NatComs and partners – in strengthening innovative construction in education using recycled plastic bricks, local production capacity remained constrained. This called for a strategic reassessment and the opening up of the market to competition.

Insufficient domestic funding has meant that the robust policy and regulatory framework on child rights, developed with UNICEF support, is not fully operationalized. Notwithstanding government ambitions for flagship initiatives like the vaccination programme and Civil Registration and Vital Statistics reform, mobilizing domestic funding remains a key challenge for sustainable results. Community-based approaches supporting interventions in health, HIV, nutrition, birth registration and SBC have also been limited in effectiveness due to the lack of formal status for CHWs, among other factors, which is affecting their motivation. This requires advocating for sustainable government funding.

Fragmentation and siloed initiatives across ministries hindered institutional coordination within cross-sectoral programme components, affecting efforts to adequately address social protection and child poverty programmatic priorities, among other spheres.

Lessons Learned

In 2024 UNICEF learned valuable lessons from programme implementation. **Leveraging evidence, knowledge and UNICEF's convening power** to develop new partnerships with external stakeholders – including public and private sectors, foundations, civil society, universities, research institutes and local authorities – is essential for comprehensive, multisectoral programming and sustainable results. Reliable, disaggregated data on children and social expenditures is crucial for guiding public policies and for assessing their impact. The body of evidence produced by UNICEF in support of the SitAn was critical in ensuring that human capital investment is prioritized under the NDP 2026-2030.

Integrated cross-sectoral approaches and geographic convergence effectively address the complex needs of children, families and communities, thereby promoting equity. Bringing services closer to rights-holders has led to more equitable results and increased community engagement. For instance, initiatives like the itinerant classroom pilot in education have enhanced enrolment, skills acquisition and reduced child labour, thereby contributing comprehensively to addressing the root causes of child deprivation.

Strengthening government institutions' operational capacities for coordinating humanitarian interventions and resilience programming has improved local authority buy-in and access to key services, especially in northern Côte d'Ivoire affected by the refugee/asylum seekers' crisis.

Strong engagement with ministries through **UNICEF-supported flagship initiatives**, partner collaboration on priorities and financing, and advocacy for effective, equitable, and sustainable public resources are key strategies to drive national priorities and accelerate results for children. This approach has secured government commitments and mobilized high-level decision-makers to support domestic financing for key social sector initiatives, including increased funding for primary health care and the immunization transition. The commitment to more and better funding for children also includes domestic funding for the SMART nutrition survey and the launch of initiatives for improving nutrition financing, such as the forthcoming round table on the Multisectoral Nutrition Strategic Plan and ongoing discussions around the taxation of unhealthy food.

UNICEF's role in **coordinating partners and facilitating strategic dialogue** with national authorities has been vital for establishing itself as the reference partner in health, nutrition, education and on adolescent and youth issues, ensuring better alignment and efficiency in implementing national social sector plans and strategies. However, a One UN approach and advocacy is required to follow up on government commitments for social sectors.

Future Outlook

Based on the challenges and lessons learned, key priorities for 2025 and beyond include:

Supporting and Accelerating Effective Implementation of Reforms: As leader of several sectoral Donor Groups – Nutrition, WASH and Social Protection – UNICEF will support national sector coordination for integrated, coherent and effective planning. This includes institutionalizing Joint Annual Sectoral Reviews to address common challenges and continuing to advocate for sector reforms.

As the country transitions from lower to upper middle-income status, addressing growing inequities becomes increasingly critical. Integrating equity strategies and programming across all sectors, focusing on transforming harmful gender norms and power imbalances, along with enhancing resilience to shocks and climate change, will be of paramount importance. UNICEF will integrate WASH components into the climate NDCs 3.0 during the review, update the process beginning in 2025 and pursue the integration of environmental and social safeguards (ESS) across programmes based on the findings of the 2024 ESS study. UNICEF will advocate for a plan to electrify schools, health facilities and social centres under the National Compact for Energy, addressing a critical barrier to service access and renewable energy adoption.

Leveraging Domestic Resources for Social Sectors and Scaling Up of Proven Initiatives: UNICEF will prioritize collaboration with sectoral ministries and the Ministry of Economy, Planning and Development to strengthen evidence generation and knowledge management on child rights, informing policy dialogue and firming up our advocacy to increase domestic resource allocations for priority programmes. Through intensified advocacy with the Ministry of Budget and Finance, domestic resource mobilization will be strengthened in support of the national vaccination programme, the multisectoral nutrition programme and the civil registration system component on birth registration.

Expanding Integration and Digitalization for Equity in Social Service Provision: Emphasis will be on addressing equity in immunization by focusing on "zero dose" children and those insufficiently vaccinated, through integrating with other programmes, such as nutrition, birth registration and WASH, to enable more equitable outreach of the most vulnerable. Following the Ministry of National Education, the Ministry of Health is prioritizing digitizing data management tools. UNICEF will collaborate to scale up the m-health pilot initiative launched in 2024. Digital solutions will be developed to enhance capacity-building, programme implementation and monitoring across key areas, such as nutrition, education and child protection, including improving birth registration.

Rethinking Partnerships for Innovation: Expanding private sector partnerships will enable UNICEF to improve educational access for vulnerable and disadvantaged children through initiatives like eco-friendly school construction, mobile digital solutions and solar-powered water systems, while also addressing child labour through strengthened service delivery systems.

Talking into account the growing social demand from the large young population, the programme will prioritize support to expanding vocational certification systems to meet market demands and to reach rural areas. Partnerships with the private sector will bridge training-employment gaps, while fostering civic participation and promoting gender equality to ensure the inclusion of marginalized groups, especially girls. UNICEF will work with the private sector to up-scale the First Foods initiative and nutrition-sensitive food systems and on the regulation of diet diversity to prevent overweight and obesity with active participation from adolescents and youth.

The 2025 outlook underscores the importance of capacity-building, system strengthening and the upscaling of high-impact initiatives, with a particular emphasis on child rights, as UNICEF transitions to the new Country Programme in 2026. This focus is particularly relevant given recent setbacks in the realization of human rights and will include efforts to enhance reporting mechanisms. To achieve this, the organization will prioritize providing technical support, engaging in advocacy and fostering policy dialogue with the government and key development partners.